Legal and ethical basics: authorization, scope, Rules of Engagement and the cyber-crime law that applies in your country.

Legal & Ethical Basics

Professional Terms

- **Authorization**: Explicit, written, and signed permission from the asset owner allowing you to test their security. Hacking without this is a crime.
- **Scope**: A strict list of exactly what you are allowed to test (specific IP addresses, domains, or apps) and what is completely off-limits.
- **Rules of Engagement (RoE)**: The guidelines of the test, specifying when you can test, how to handle sensitive data, and who to contact if something crashes.

Dutch Cyber Crime Law

In the Netherlands, cybersecurity testing is governed by the Dutch Criminal Code (Wetboek van Strafrecht).

- **Primary Law**: **Article 138ab (Computervredebreuk)**.
- **What it means**: This law explicitly criminalizes unauthorized digital intrusion. Even if you don't steal or damage anything, simply breaking into a system or network that you do not have permission to access is illegal.
- **Consequences**: Violating this law can result in heavy fines or prison time, which is why having signed authorization paperwork before touching a client's system is absolutely critical.